Swim Star Tatjana Smith Changes Teams

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Tatjana Smith is South Africa's most **decorated** Olympian. Now she will swim for the Netherlands. Smith won four Olympic medals in **breaststroke**, including two golds, before she **retired** after the Paris 2024 Games. She came back to swimming in September. She hopes to race in the 50m **breaststroke** at the 2028 Games in Los Angeles, when the event is held for the first time at the Olympics. Smith has dual **citizenship** because her father is Dutch. She said she has 'always been Dutch and South African.' She also said the move gives her more support and a better chance to build a lasting career. Money worries had helped push her to stop swimming before. 'Representing South Africa was a childhood dream come true,' she said. 'But dreams can change as we grow.' Smith will keep living and training in South Africa. She will first swim for the Netherlands at the short course World **Championships** from December 1 to 6. She knows the switch may disappoint some fans. South Africa's sports **ministry** said, 'South Africa does not own her.'

Word Treasure

decorated -- A decorated athlete is one who has won many medals.

breaststroke -- Breaststroke is a way of swimming on your front with arms sweeping in a circle.

citizenship -- Citizenship means belonging to a country as one of its people.

retired -- Retired means stopped working or competing for good.

championships -- Championships are big contests to find the best in a sport.

ministry -- A ministry is a part of a government that looks after one area, like sports.

Background you need

The Olympics are the biggest sports games in the world, held every four years.

Swimmers race for the country they represent, and some athletes have citizenship in two countries.

Athletes sometimes switch countries when they think another team gives them more support and a better chance to keep competing.

Break it down

WHO: Tatjana Smith, South Africa's most decorated Olympian.

WHAT: Smith will now swim for the Netherlands, hoping to race in the 50m breaststroke at the 2028 Games in Los Angeles.

WHERE: In South Africa, where she will keep living and training, and at races around the world.

WHY: Because her father is Dutch, she has dual citizenship, and the move gives her more support and a better chance to build a lasting career.

Why it matters

Athletes get to choose their own path, and seeing someone chase a dream in a new place shows that changing your mind is part of growing up.

Test what you remember

1. Who is Tatjana Smith?

(A) A sports minister
(B) A Dutch singer
(C) South Africa's most decorated Olympian
(D) A swimming coach

2. How many Olympic medals did Smith win?

(A) Two
(B) One
(C) Four
(D) Six

3. When did Smith retire before her comeback?

(A) After the 2028 Games
(B) Before the Paris Games
(C) After the Paris 2024 Games
(D) In September

4. What event does Smith hope to race in at the 2028 Games?

(A) The 50m breaststroke
(B) The 100m freestyle
(C) The 200m backstroke
(D) The 400m medley

5. Why does Smith have dual citizenship?

(A) Because she married a Dutch swimmer
(B) Because she was born in the Netherlands
(C) Because her father is Dutch
(D) Because she trains in the Netherlands

6. What did South Africa's sports ministry say?

(A) 'The switch is not allowed'
(B) 'She must stay in South Africa'
(C) 'South Africa does not own her'
(D) 'She will regret her choice'

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: C 3: C 4: A 5: C 6: C

Questions to think about

1. Tatjana Smith: Says she has 'always been Dutch and South African' and that dreams can change as we grow.

2. South Africa's sports ministry: Said, 'South Africa does not own her.'

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):